

Μνησιμάχος ὁ κωμικός

Pythagorean Dining in the Fragments of Mnesimachus

eul_aid: fpk

Period: Κλασική Classical
Dialect: Ἀττική Attic (com, frg)
Domain: Κωμωδία Comedy
Format: Ἑμμετρος Verse

Mnesimachus was an Athenian comic poet of the Middle Comedy period, active in the 4th century BCE. No biographical details about his life survive. His floruit is generally placed in the mid-4th century, based on a fragment from his play **The Horse-breeder** that mentions the contemporary military commander Iphicrates.

He is known only through surviving fragments. The **Suda** attributes two plays to him: **The Horse-breeder** and **The Busiris**. The writer Athenaeus also cites a play titled **Phaon**. Approximately fifteen fragments survive, primarily preserved in Athenaeus's **Deipnosophistae**. These offer glimpses of his style but are insufficient for reconstructing any plot.

Mnesimachus is a representative figure of the fragmentary record of Middle Comedy. His significance lies in the textual evidence his fragments provide for this transitional period. The fragments show characteristic themes of the era: **The Horse-breeder** parodies a military dispatch, while **Busiris** treats mythology. Common references to food and domestic life illustrate the period's broader shift toward social and everyday humor.

Works (2)

- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Πυθαγορικῆς Συμποσίας · [Fragments on Pythagorean Dining](#) · 37 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Πυθαγορικῆς Θυσίας · [Fragments on Pythagorean Sacrifice](#) · 38 passages